



near-perfect 10-1 record in five-set matches in his young career. Sascha matched that with a 10-1 mark in five-setters at Roland Garros.

Sascha lost the mental game when he lost his serve and fell behind 2-1. Two bad volley errors, a double fault, and an unforced backhand error gave the game away.

Alcaraz, who admires Michael Jordan and tries to emulate the NBA superstar's clutch play, fought off three break points at 0-40. After he played great defence and then put away a smash on one break point, the crowd rewarded his super hustling with a standing ovation. When he held serve for 3-1 with a perfect drop shot, chants of "Carlos! Carlos!" reverberated around the stadium.

The phenom who, as a boy, idolised Nadal but modelled his game on Federer was now virtually unstoppable. Zverev was down 2-4, love-30 in a must-win game when Alcaraz hit the shot of the match, if not the tournament. After he sprinted across the length of the baseline, he improvised a crosscourt slice

Young and hungry: The clash between Alcaraz and Jannik Sinner was the youngest Grand Slam semifinal since Andy Murray defeated Rafael Nadal at the 2008 US Open. AFP

backhand passing shot winner with one hand. Zverev shot a long stare toward him that translated to "Did you really make that shot?"

Alcaraz broke serve with his trademark inside-out forehand winner and then routinely held serve for a 3-6, 6-2, 5-7, 6-1, 6-2 triumph and his third Grand Slam title.

After his on-court victory celebration, Alcaraz rushed to the player's box where his team, family, and friends hugged him. His parents shed tears of joy. His coach Juan Carlos Ferrero, who won Roland Garros in 2003, beamed with pride.

Zverev graciously showered the champion with praise. "He's a beast. He's an animal. The intensity he plays tennis at is different to other people. He played fantastic. He played better than me in the fourth and fifth set. It's

how it is. I felt like this Grand Slam final I did everything I could. At the [2020] US Open, I kind of gave it away myself. It's a bit different [here]."

Alcaraz pointed to his mental fortitude as the key to the deciding set. "You have to give your heart. In those moments, it's where the top players give their best tennis," he explained.

"I wanted to be one of the best tennis players in the world, so I have to give extra in those moments in the fifth set, I have to show the opponent that I am fresh, I'm [acting] like we are playing the first game of the match. That works pretty well if the opponents see me that I'm moving well, I'm hitting the good shots, I'm finding good solutions. And of course, mental strength plays a great part in that moment if you want to win the Slams."

As a reward for winning Slams, Alcaraz gets a tattoo with the date of the final and a symbol of the venue. "Another tattoo with the Eiffel Tower will be soon," Alcaraz said. "I wanted to win this tournament since I was a